

SI-MI: Social Identity Matters in Mentoring

A 7-session course on culturally responsive mentorship in STEM
August 28 - November 20, 2026

Course Format: 7 virtual synchronous sessions (90 minutes each) held biweekly with brief pre-work assigned between sessions (read/watch/reflect).

Audience: Faculty, staff, postdocs, graduate students, and anyone mentoring in STEM learning/work environments.

A Note on Vulnerability: In most academic and scientific settings, we are taught to leave our emotions at the door because science is supposed to be objective and rational. However, the humans conducting the science are not merely rational beings. This course aims to bring awareness to our emotions and how those emotions manifest in our social interactions, including mentoring. This will likely require significant vulnerability and may feel uncomfortable at first. Please know that this course is intentionally designed around vulnerability to strengthen our relationships with ourselves, our colleagues, and mentees. Participants are encouraged to meet their growth edge while knowing the limits of what they want to share.

Course Description: Many of us have attended at least one mentoring workshop in our careers, and we would like to emphasize that SI-MI will probably feel very different. We are not here to learn the dos and don'ts of mentorship or a formula that we can adopt with every mentee. We are here to unlearn what societies and institutions have taught us about mentorship and dive deeply into what culturally responsive mentorship looks like. This will require significant introspection and emotional labor, which will be difficult but ultimately rewarding and (we hope) transformative.

This course builds a shared foundation for culturally responsive mentorship and offers practical tools to recognize how social identity, power, and systemic inequities shape mentoring relationships in STEM. Across seven sessions, participants will examine identity and intersectionality, practice empathic and accountable communication, learn to name and challenge racism and color-evasive practices, shift from deficit thinking to asset-based mentoring, and apply an integrated framework through mentoring-plan critique and role-play.

Learning Outcomes

- Describe how identity and intersectionality influence participation and belonging in STEM.
- Use empathic, bi-directional communication strategies for difficult mentoring conversations.
- Recognize how systemic racism (not just interpersonal bias) shapes mentoring contexts in academia.
- Identify and interrupt color-evasive language and practices that harm mentees of color.
- Adopt asset-based approaches that affirm strengths and community cultural wealth.
- Apply course tools to real mentoring artifacts (plans/agreements) and complex scenarios.

Participation and expectations

- Come prepared; complete the pre-work and bring reflections, and be ready to take notes in whatever way makes sense for you.
- Participate actively in discussion, paired/small-group activities, and skill practice.
- Engage with respect, confidentiality, and curiosity; expect discomfort as part of learning.
- Center impact over intent; prioritize mentee needs and well-being in applied activities.

Community Guidelines: By participating in the SI-MI course, we agree to follow the community guidelines [outlined here](#) (developed by Dra. Nicole Cabrera Salazar, Movement Consulting). These guidelines ensure that we are engaging with each other and the material from a place of openness that will enhance learning. An overview of these guidelines will be provided during Session 1.

Session Overview

1. **Session 1: Orientation** — Build trust and shared norms; clarify mentoring goals and expectations.
2. **Session 2: Identity and its Intersections** — Explore identity, privilege, and intersectionality; apply to mentoring case studies.
3. **Session 3: Engaging in Empathic Conversations** — Practice empathy-centered approaches for difficult conversations and feedback.
4. **Session 4: Racialized Experiences in STEM** — Examine systemic racism in STEM and what culturally aware mentoring can and cannot do.
5. **Session 5: Color-Evasive Practices** — Identify and interrupt color-evasive language; practice race-aware, accountable responses.

6. **Session 6: From Deficit to Asset-Based Mentoring** — Shift from deficit framing to strengths-based mentoring; name and affirm community cultural wealth.
7. **Session 7: Embodying Culturally Responsive Mentorship** — Integrate course lessons through mentoring-plan critique and role-play; close with reflection and gratitude.

Accessibility and Support

We aim to create a learning environment where participants can engage fully. If you need accommodations or have access needs (e.g., captions, materials in advance, alternative ways to participate), please contact the instructor(s) as early as possible.

Course Logistics

Live Sessions: Biweekly on Fridays at 11am - 12:30pm PDT // 1-2:30pm CDT // 2-3:30pm EDT

Zoom Link:

<https://us06web.zoom.us/j/86286141597?pwd=lvf9LUGDe3x2CyxgPyflbPiEkdxU9P.1>

Password: SIMI2026

Participant Folder

Holds all readings and documents for the course in one place

SI-MI Live Sessions + Pre-Work			
<u>Session</u>	<u>Live Session Date</u>	<u>Pre-Work</u>	<u>Due Date</u>
<u>Session 1:</u> Orientation	August 28, 2026	Read  MVMT Community Guidel...	August 27, 2026
<u>Session 2:</u> Identity and its Intersections	September 11, 2026	Read  15 Examples of Intersectio... Watch <u>TED Talk - The Urgency of Intersectionality</u> by Kimberlé Crenshaw Complete  Academic Wheel of Privil...	September 10, 2026
<u>Session 3:</u> Engaging in Empathic Conversations	September 25, 2026	Watch <u>-Aiko Bethea on Inclusivity at Work: The Heart of Hard Conversations</u> Sign up for reading <u>here</u> Read ONE: <u>Martinez-Cola (2020).</u> <u>Benishek et al. (2004).</u> <u>Tanner & Allen (2007).</u> Complete reflection questions	September 24, 2026
<u>Session 4:</u> Racialized Experiences in STEM	October 9, 2026	Read  Scientists from historicall... Listen <u>The Pitt Pulse Podcast Episode 1</u> Complete reflection questions	October 8, 2026

SI-MI Live Sessions + Pre-Work			
<u>Session 5:</u> Color-Evasive Practices	October 23, 2026	Watch - Color Blind or Color Brave? - Color Evasiveness Complete reflection questions	October 22, 2026
<u>Session 6:</u> From Deficit to Asset-Based Mentoring	November 6, 2026	Read:  From Deficits to Possibilit...  Whose Culture has Capit... Complete reflection questions	November 5, 2026
<u>Session 7:</u> Embodying Culturally Responsive Mentorship	November 20, 2026	Review:  Wilson Research Assistan...  McMahon Mentor-Mente... Sign up:  Session 7 Pre-Work Sign-...  Session 7: Role-Play Scen...	November 19, 2026